



Returned, But Empty

A Fate Census of 1,184 School-Fete Raffle Books and the Participation Rate That Counts Them All

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Motivation

A fete committee reports a participation rate: the share of issued raffle books that come back. A book returned unsold and a book returned full both count as a return. How much of a reported figure is carried by books that raised nothing?

Research questions

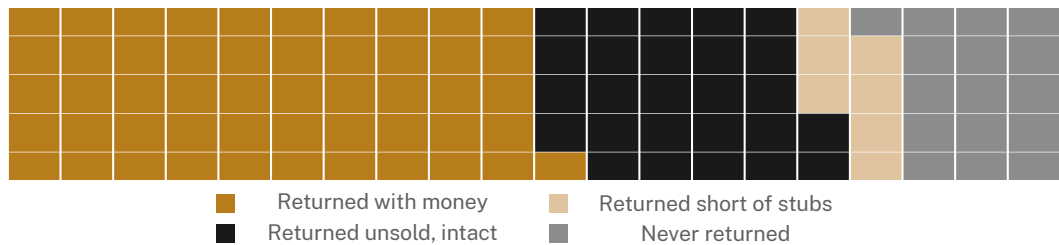
- The end state of every issued book, coded to a scheme fixed before the season.
- The share of a reported participation rate carried by books returning no money.
- Whether reconciliation time depends on what a returned book carries.

Study design

- 1,184 pre-numbered books · 9 primary-school fetes · 11-week selling window · counting-table observation.
- Return state double-coded to five categories; disagreements resolved against the stub sequence.
- Reconciliation timed to the second; coding rules and equivalence bounds lodged before the first fete, none adjusted post hoc.

What we found

Books returning in any state account for 84% of issued stock; books carrying money account for 51%. Reconciliation time is indistinguishable between money-bearing and empty returns (median difference 0.2 min, inside a pre-registered ± 0.75 min bound).



End state of 100 issued books, March–May 2026 (n = 1,184): 51 return carrying money (13 only after a reissue reminder), 26 return unsold and intact, 7 return short of their stubs, 16 never return. The participation rate counts the first three.

Implications

The indicator is not misreported: it counts returns, which is what it was defined to count. A reissue reminder lifts it by moving books between return states rather than by selling tickets. A committee quoting 84% is quoting its own definition back.

Next: a season-length trial recording money-bearing returns on a separate line, tabled with the Indicator Commons.

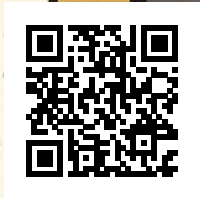
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Books de-identified at the counting table; no family or purchaser detail retained. Coding scheme and bounds lodged before the first fete. We thank the volunteer committees of the participating schools.

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“Eighty-four per cent of books came back. Fifty-one per cent came back with money.”

1,184 books · nine school fetes · one 11-week selling season